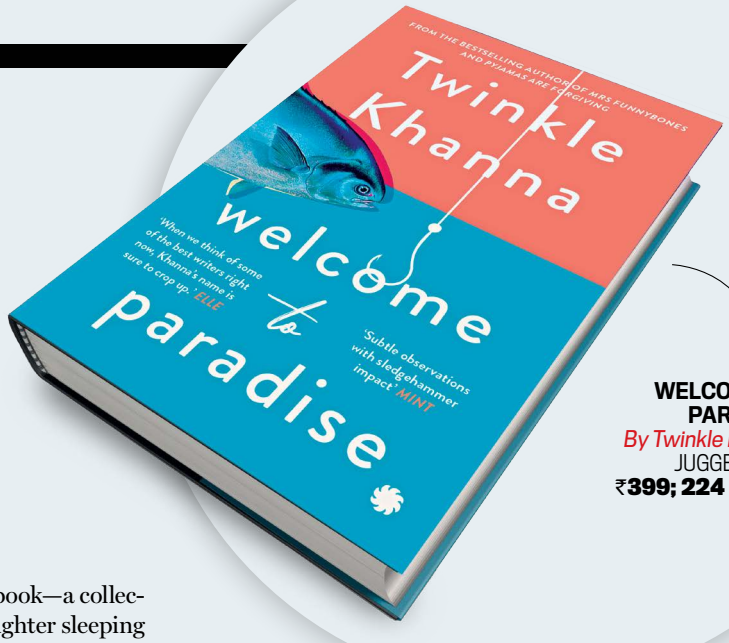


WELCOME TO PARADISE
By Twinkle Khanna
JUGGERNAUT
₹399; 224 pages

Welcome to Paradise, Twinkle Khanna's latest book—a collection of short stories—came to life with her daughter sleeping beside her, in a dark room illuminated by a laptop screen. There's no waiting for the muse for the disciplined Twinkle, who starts writing between 4.30 and 5 am, nearly every day. "You sit at your desk, and if the muse is on their way to someone else, you are right there to catch her and bring her carcass to your desk," she says. Twinkle's other writerly hack is to use a terrible font for her first draft—"so I am not intimidated by the idea of perfection at that stage".

The title may seem breezy, but these are tales from a less-than-perfect world, delivered in Twinkle's trademark wry humour, her "salve over life's innate calamities" that she employs to such splendid effect in her avatar as celebrity columnist Mrs Funnybones. "The title is subversive; everything that appears idyllic on the surface may have a different reality underneath," she says. "I didn't set out to write stories that dealt with mortality, loss, and love, but there were images floating inside my head like trays of jelly sweets setting on a terrace, or a particular anecdote that then made its way into 'Let's Pretend' about the young, flat-chested girl who gets advice about a vigorous breast massage."

BEING HUMOROUS IS IN TWINKLE'S NATURE. "WHEN LIFE THROWS ME A CURVEBALL, I STICK IT ON MY NOSE AND START CLOWNING AROUND," SHE SAYS

The collection has been in the works, on and off, for a while. For instance, Twinkle started writing the story 'Jelly Sweets' almost eight years ago, and yet it was the last story she completed. There are five stories in the book, including one that lends the collection its name. The first—'The Man from the Garage'—opens with the hardly paradisal scene of a just deceased 'Amma' lying in a refrigerated case in her daughter's cramped apartment as the relatives argue over her last rites. Amma was born into an Ismaili Muslim family and married a Hindu who, despite converting to placate her parents, was cremated when he died. So now there is Team Crematorium and Team Cemetery battling it out. It's no coincidence that Twinkle's own grandmother was an Ismaili Muslim. "Amma is based not just on my grandmother but all her sisters and cousins," she says. "My grandmother had a large hand in raising me; the one thing I have inherited from her is the ability to use my hands constantly as a way of stilling my mind."

The title story, about a couple who stray—first the husband, and then the wife to even the score—plays out in Goa, the Indian city slicker's idea of paradise. "I usually write about women and the displacement within their lives. It is an issue that deeply interests me," says Twinkle. "In terms of settling on a subject, the story has to keep rattling inside my head. I make notes and put them away.... After a few months or even years, I'll look at my notes and start working out the details."

As for employing humour to address serious issues, Mrs Funnybones opines, "If you can make someone laugh, then you have created a visceral reaction that changes the way they view that issue. It is also my inherent nature; when life throws me a curveball, I stick it on my nose and start clowning around. I remember coming back from the hospital after a devastating miscarriage, sitting in my garden with my friends and family and cracking jokes about my terrible day."

Twinkle was drawn to words at an early age and could, apparently, read by the time she was three. "I doubt that it's true, but it does help me tease my sister who started reading at five. Perhaps it was our childhood and the access to so many books, but we have both grown up to be readers," she says. By age 14, Twinkle was hooked to science fiction. Of course, her reading has widened since then and she counts Arundhati Roy, Alice Munro, Zadie Smith and Chimam-